The decade that Humayun and Akbar would spend in Kabul was not a time of arid ‘exile’, which was often the narrative of nineteenth-century British historians like Mountstuart Elphinstone or H. M. Elliot. It was a time charmed by bracing creativity in which various subterranean streams of legitimacy and art were adopted to form the very beginning of Mughal art and culture. Art historian Laura E. Parodi has shown that the Kabul years were essential to the development of the Mughal school, and that this movement began very early in Humayun’s reign. From 1545 onwards, Humayun established a fully-fledged kitab khana which employed Khurasani trained artists who, it is now believed, probably worked for Humayun from an even earlier time, predating his Persian interlude. There was another artist with Humayun in Kabul, Dust Muhammad of Herat, also intriguingly known as Dust-e Divana, or Dust the Fool. The chronicler Bayazid Bayat wrote about Dust Muhammad’s ‘fondness for wine, which he was unable to give up’ but which he was now able to continue at Humayun’s more indulgent court.

Amidst the brooding chinar trees and flushed pomegranate blossoms of Kabul, Dust Muhammad painted a masterpiece of refinement, allegory, and symbolism now believed to commemorate the feasts around Akbar’s circumcision. In this extraordinary piece of work, there are rocks in the shape of an elephant, alluding to Humayun’s dream of Ahmad of Jam, the Colossal Elephant. There are, unusually, large groups of women, identified as Hamida Banu, Gulbadan, Bega Begum, Gulbarg Begum, and Maham Anaga, and there are identifiable caves and rocks that place the event almost certainly at Khwaja Seh Yaran, outside Kabul. Indeed, in the use of symbolic accoutrements like headgear, clothes, colours etc., for particular persons and places, this painting represents one of the very first attempts at ‘portraiture’ in Mughal art. All these elements are clues to the tapestry of Akbar’s later vision and the importance of the role of Mughal women, but they are also an acknowledgement, now forgotten, of the enormous debt Mughal art owed to Humayun.

Though the art continued, peace in Kabul was illusory for Kamran had not abdicated his claim. For the next few years, the tussle continued, and during one of Humayun’s absences, Kamran took possession of Kabul and the Mughal household once again. At one point, when Kabul was being besieged by Humayun who was preparing for his great guns to be fired at the fort, in a cold-blooded and dastardly act, Kamran placed the young